Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Rudyard Kipling's "The Fabulists"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the role of the creative artist in a world that is defined by the speaker's observation, "Truth is seldom Friend to any crowd," the speaker's emphasis on the world's willingness to "keep a matter hid" serving as the immediate context, include

alliteration,
allusion,
anaphora,
assonance,
chiasmus,
consonance,
didactic literature,
epistrophe,
(*examples*: jeremiad, parody, satire),
imagery,
inversion (anastrophe, hyperbaton),
metaphor,
personification,
reification,
resonance,
rhetorical question,
rhyme and rhythm,
simile,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer might well recognize embedded in the poem's first line the clichéd, painfully self-evident truism, ignorance is bliss.

The contestant might perceive in the third stanza the speaker's focus on the small return ("reward") that writers receive—even when what they offer (to themselves as well as their audiences), "the small pleasure in imaginings" (line 28) that are "not heard at all" (each stanza's final phrase [epistrophe]). The didactic, the prophetic, the simple reporting, even when rendered as fable (line 3), as didactic literature, as creative imaginings, fail in the face of apathy, ignorance, and whatever might be understood by line 12's "Unless men please[,] they are not heard at all."

The contestant might recognize that Kipling's attention to form—the iambic lines and the structured rhyme scheme—is antithetical to the inherent lamentation that characterizes the poem, especially, the lines "*This* was the lock that lay upon our lips, / This was the yoke that we have undergone" (lines 19-20): While Kipling's nineteenth-century versifying is wedded to the characteristics of the closed form, a release from the closed-form strictures might, were it chosen, contribute to the speaker's point, line 28's rhetorical question "What man shall pleasure in imaginings?" Conversely, the contestant might argue that the speaker's lyrical call (qualities that "please" [line12]) for freedom from the lock and the yoke finds adequate voice in spite of the lock and yoke's insistence: the strict iambic and the unflawed rhyme scheme.

NB: The student might recognize something contemporary in Kipling's theme; however, that he or she makes a connection between Kipling's observation and the world immediate should be weighted as value added: essays should be judged (and thus compared) primarily for their literary analysis. That the student finds and argues resonance is, indeed, more than serendipitous, if you will; however, explicatory analysis must herald or weave through any application to the present.